
FROM SIBLING RIVALRY TO FRIENDS AND CONFIDANTS

Lesson One

Read the Pattern

Why it happens: attachment, threat, and the very ordinary jealousy of being small.

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Before we start

Most of what looks like a behaviour problem is actually a feelings problem wearing a disguise. A grabbed toy, a sudden meltdown, a nasty word thrown at a brother or sister: none of it comes out of nowhere. It's a small person telling you something big, in the only language they have in that moment.

This lesson is about learning to read what's underneath. Not so you can excuse the behaviour, but so you can respond to what's actually happening instead of what it looks like on the surface.

The one thing to hold onto

Behaviour is something a child does. It is never who a child is.

A child who grabs a toy isn't "a grabby kid." They're a kid whose whole body is saying threat right now: I might be about to lose something I need. The behaviour is telling you what's happening in this moment. It isn't a verdict on their character.

The second we forget that, the second "he's so jealous" or "she's just dramatic" slips out, even said gently, even said in our own heads, two things start to go wrong. The child starts to believe it, and starts living up to it. And we stop looking for the reason underneath, because we've quietly decided we already know who they are.

So here's the discipline for this whole lesson: describe what happened, never who they are. "You grabbed the toy," not "you're so grabby." "This is hard for you right now," not "you're jealous of your brother."

What you'll actually see, and what it's really telling you

Here are five patterns that come up again and again. Think of each one as a little translation guide: what it looks like, what it's probably about, and what tends to help.

1. Grabbing or hoarding toys, especially right after the baby feeds or gets picked up

You'll see: Sudden possessiveness over things they weren't even playing with a minute ago.

What's really going on: This is a threat response, not selfishness. Something that felt safe (your closeness, your attention) just visibly went somewhere else, and grabbing is how a small body tries to hold on to what's left.

Try this: Go to Name It, Ground It, Talk It. "I can see you want to be close to me too. Let's sit for a minute." Skip the sharing lecture for now; connection comes first, the lesson about sharing can wait a few minutes.

2. Regression: baby talk, accidents, wanting to be carried again

You'll see: A child who was toilet-trained having accidents, or a big kid suddenly wanting a bottle or a carry, right around when a new sibling arrives.

What's really going on: This isn't manipulation and it isn't "being difficult." It's a very reasonable question in disguise: does being small still get me loved? They're testing it out to find the answer.

Try this: Meet it with warmth, not correction. A few days of answering the baby voice gently tends to resolve faster than a few days of "you're a big kid now" pressure ever does.

3. Conflict that flares up exactly when you're distracted

You'll see: The moment you pick up the phone, or turn to feed the other one, suddenly there's a fight.

What's really going on: This one isn't scheming; it's an accurate read of the world. If conflict reliably gets a response and calm doesn't, of course conflict is what shows up when attention is needed.

Try this: Where you can, catch the calm moments out loud too. "I noticed you two were playing so nicely together," so attention isn't only available through a fight.

4. Sudden meanness right after a sibling gets praised

You'll see: A compliment to one child, and a sharp or unkind word from the other, almost immediately after.

What's really going on: This is comparison pain, not cruelty. In that instant, the thought is something like: if they're good at that, what am I good at? It stings, and it comes out sideways.

Try this: Name the feeling before the words. "That was hard to hear, wasn't it, your brother getting praised like that." Once they're calmer, you can circle back to the unkind words on their own.

5. Pushback or complaining when asked to "be the big one"

You'll see: Loud resistance, huffing, or flat refusal when asked to help with or make space for a younger sibling.

What's really going on: Often this is simply a gap between what they're being asked to carry emotionally and what they're actually ready for at their age. Expectations may have quietly crept ahead of their development.

Try this: Lower the ask before you raise the consequence. A useful check: is this genuinely reasonable for their age, or just convenient for mine right now?

The language that makes the difference

Small wording shifts, big difference in what a child hears about themselves.

Instead of...	Try...
<i>You're being so jealous.</i>	Something's feeling hard right now. Is it about your brother?
<i>Stop being so dramatic.</i>	That felt big to you. Let's sit with it for a minute.
<i>Why can't you just share?</i>	Sharing my attention is hard sometimes. Let's figure this out together.
<i>He's the difficult one, she's the easy one.</i>	(Retire this one for good. Even said quietly, it shapes how we treat them.)

Bringing it back to Name It, Ground It, Talk It

Every pattern above leads to the same place. This lesson is what makes that tool sharp instead of generic: once you can recognise which signal you're looking at, the naming step ("I can see you're...") becomes accurate instead of a guess.

And accuracy is what makes a child feel seen, rather than diagnosed.